

Airport Hacks

Cheat Sheet — From Check-In to Gate in Record Time

THE PERFECT AIRPORT TIMELINE

- T-48h** Online check-in opens. Choose window seats NOW — they're gone within hours.
- T-24h** Reconfirm flight status. Download boarding pass offline in case Wi-Fi fails.
- T-3h** International minimum. Earlier = calmer. Security lines are unpredictable.
- T-2h** Security done. Go to your gate first, then find food — never the other way.
- T-45m** Final boarding call. Be physically AT the gate, not walking towards it.
- T-20m** Gates close without exception. Airlines will not wait — even 1 minute late.

SECURITY SPEED HACKS

- ♦ Slip-on shoes only — removes the lace-tying step. Saves 2+ minutes every single trip.
- ♦ Belt, coins and jacket go into your bag BEFORE you join the queue, not at the tray.
- ♦ Laptop in a dedicated top pocket — out in 3 seconds, back in 3 seconds. No digging.
- ♦ Liquids bag at the very top of your backpack — pull it out before reaching the trays.
- ♦ TSA PreCheck or EU fast-track lane: a separate line that's often 5× shorter. Worth it.

LOUNGE ACCESS WITHOUT BUSINESS CLASS

- Priority Pass** Amex Platinum & Curve Metal include free Priority Pass — 1,400+ lounges
- LoungeBuddy App** Buy a day pass from €25–40 for any lounge. Book ahead — walk-ins often f
- DragonPass** Standalone app for booking individual lounge visits in 100+ countries.
- Card Perks** Check your card's fine print: many credit cards include 2 free lounge vi

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YOUR DELAY RIGHTS (EU261)

EU261 Compensation

- 1 EU flight delayed 3h+? You're owed €250–600 per person. Applies to EU airlines worldwide AND any airline flying to/from EU.

AirHelp App

- 2 Submit your delay claim for free via AirHelp — they handle everything. You pay only if you win (30% fee).

Meal Vouchers

- 3 For delays of 2h+, ask at the gate for meal vouchers immediately. Airlines rarely hand them out unprompted.

Hotel + Transfer

- 4 Flight cancelled or delayed overnight? The airline MUST provide free hotel, meals and transport. Ask, don't wait.

UPGRADE SECRETS

Dress Smart

- 5 Looking presentable raises your upgrade chances 3×. Staff upgrade people they'd be comfortable seating in Business.

Just Ask

- 6 "Is there any business class availability today?" — costs you nothing. Works surprisingly often on short-haul.

Check-In Last

- 7 On overbooked flights, the last passengers to check in are often bumped up to fill Business Class gaps.

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Bid Upgrade

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Lufthansa, BA, KLM & others offer upgrade bidding 48h before departure. Start 20% above minimum bid.

LAYOVER PLAYBOOK

2h

Stay airside. Go to your gate first, confirm it's correct, then eat or shop nearby.

4h

Use a lounge — nap, shower, real food. Lounge access pays for itself vs. airport price

6h+

Consider a visa-free city visit. Dubai, Istanbul, Singapore all allow this with no visa

Overnight

Book a capsule hotel or lounge sleep pod in advance. Airport floors are noisy and cold

QUICK REFERENCE

- | | | |
|---------------------------|---------------------|------------------------------|
| ✓ Boarding pass (offline) | ✓ Charger + adapter | ✓ Water (buy after security) |
| ✓ Snacks | ✓ Neck pillow | ✓ Eye mask + earplugs |